The Sayyids of Barha, a clan of Indian Muslims recruited to Akbar's court and hugely valuable to his empire, spoke in Salim's favour and left the meeting. Others followed suit.

Salim was camped across the river. He had been warned not to enter the palace, according to Asad Beg, or he would be imprisoned – or worse – by Man Singh and Aziz. The prince was waiting to hear the council's decision, wondering whether to stay or flee, when the amirs began to arrive, one by one. By the end of the day, the tide had turned so completely in Salim's favour that even Aziz 'came in great shame and paid his respects'.[26]

Man Singh, meanwhile, took Khusro out of the Agra fort and prepared his boats: if need be, they would escape to Bengal.

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It is hardly possible that Aziz and Man Singh decided to make Khusro emperor all on their own. As Munis Faruqui writes, 'Almost to the end of his reign . . . Akbar seems to have held out hope that Salim's imperial claims might somehow be thwarted.'[27]

Was he disappointed, now, to see his son walk in? Or did he reconcile himself to the fact that it was, after all, the son he had prayed for who was at his deathbed, seeking his blessings? Abul Fazl might have been able to explain it in a way that soothed the dying emperor: even Akbar, he might have said, could not undo the destiny that Akbar's prayers had invoked.

There was little time for regrets, in any case. The emperor 'was still breathing', writes Asad Beg, but only just.

At his father's signal, Salim put on Akbar's turban and robes, strapped Akbar's sword around his waist. The sword had belonged to Babur; and Babur, too, had given it to Humayun as he lay dying and uncertain of what his son would make of Hindustan.

Asad Beg says that Akbar watched Salim put on these symbols of his rule, watched the attendants prostrate themselves before their new ruler, and '. . . closed his life'. Another near-contemporary historian called Ni'matullah Khan Harvi, however, describes the emperor as much more alive to the happenings around him; maybe even, in the end, approving of them.[28]